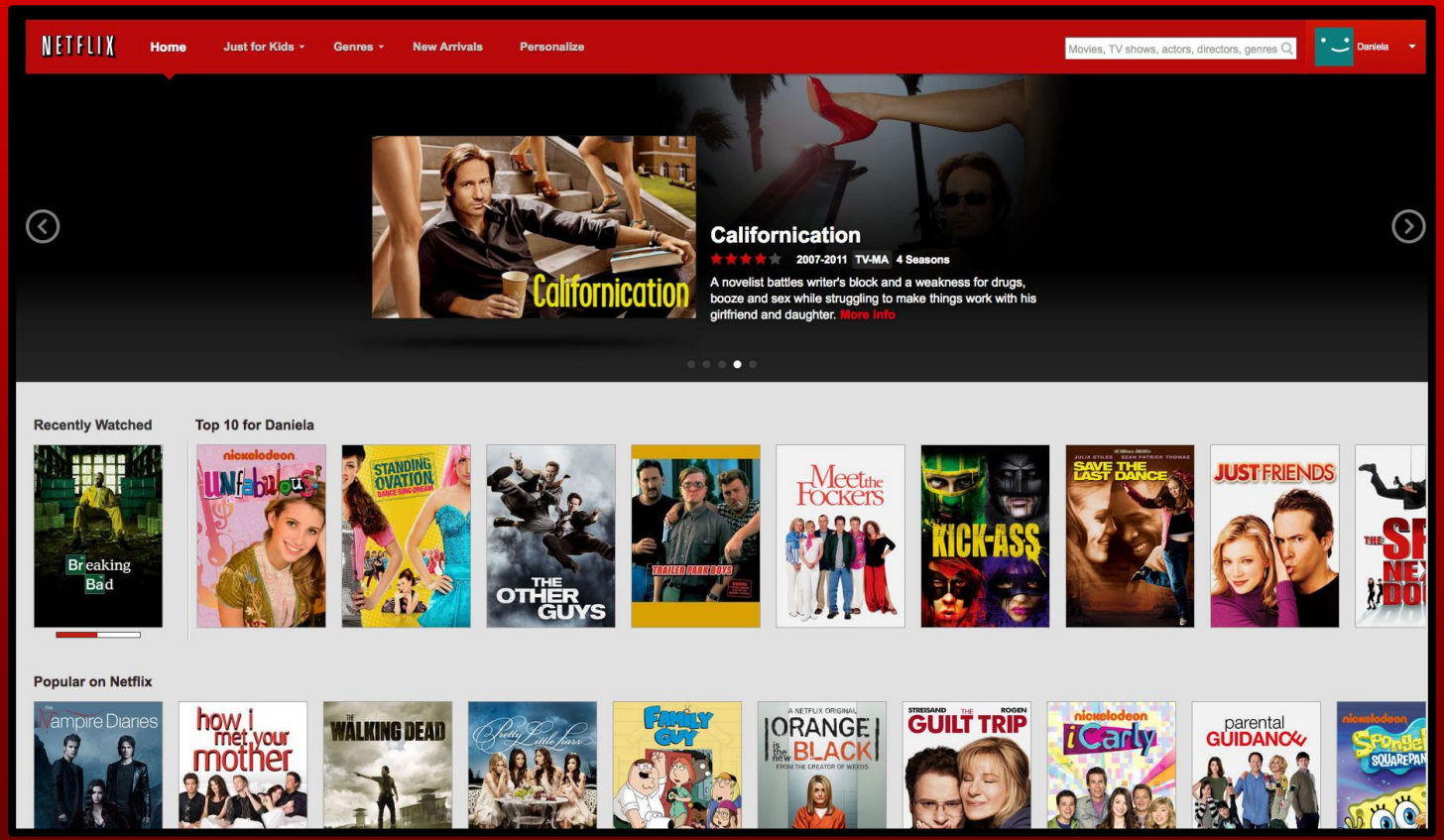
NAD v. Netflix: A Landmark Case for Accessible Streaming

CM2045

Midterm Case Study Presentation

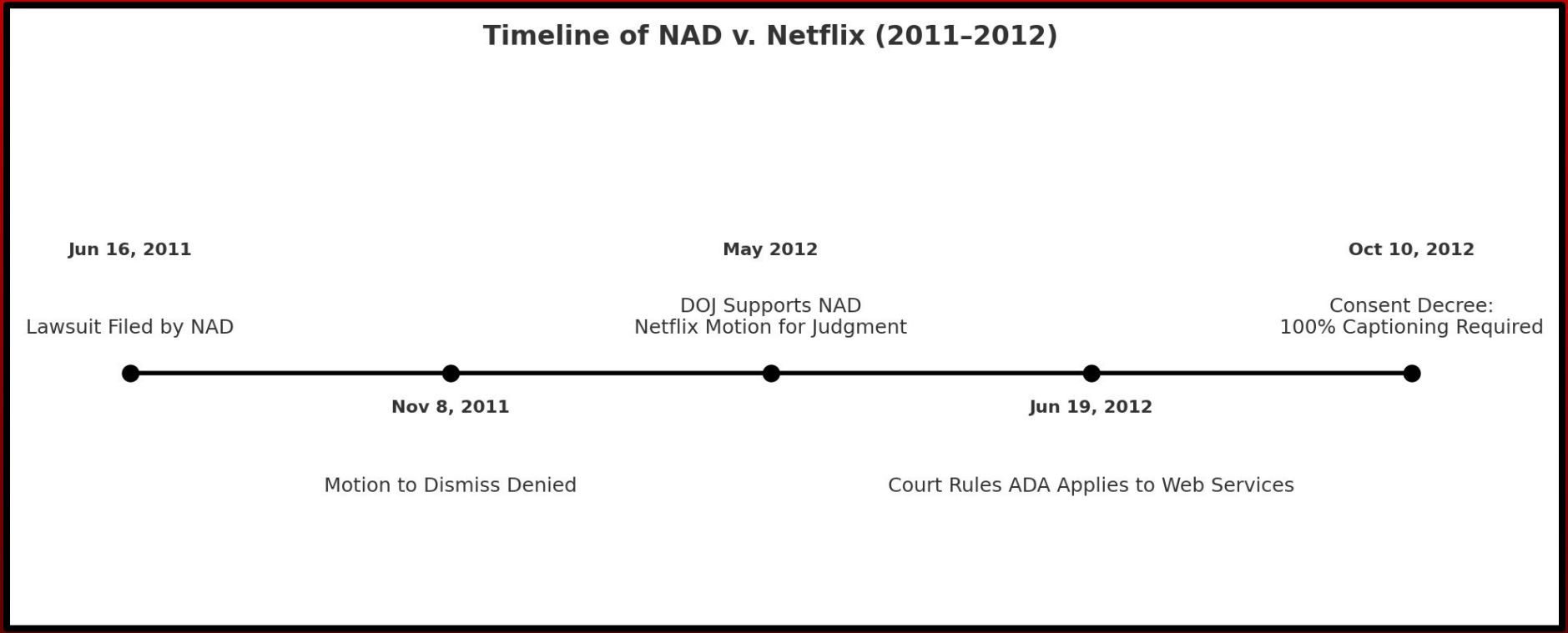


Img: Netflix 2011 UI

Background

- Netflix dominated streaming in 2011, but lacked closed captions on most content.
- NAD (National Association of the Deaf) advocated for equal access.
- Without captions, deaf users were excluded from digital media.
- NAD filed a lawsuit under ADA Title III to compel change.

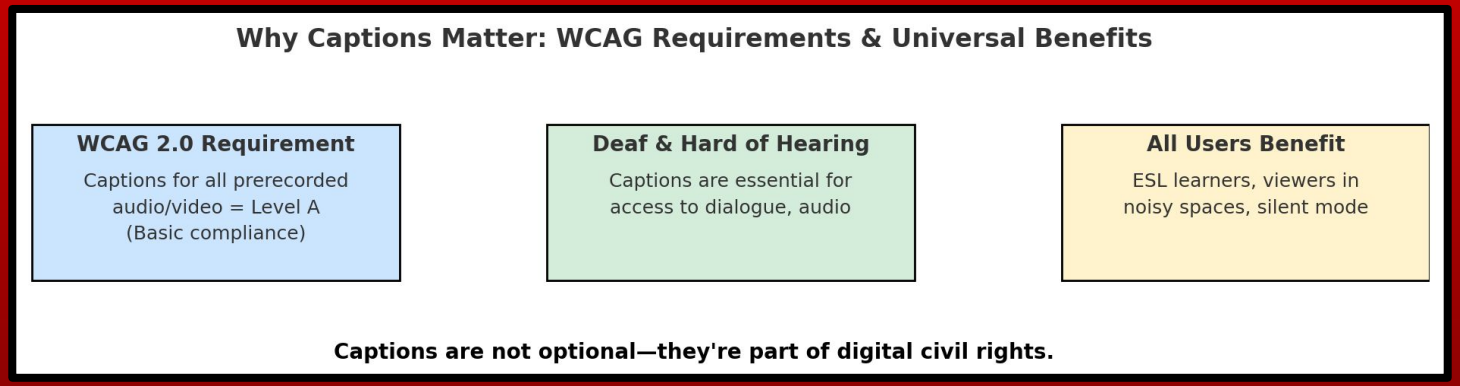
What happened?



Key Legal Milestones (2011–2012)

- Jun 2011: NAD filed lawsuit
- Nov 2011: Motion to dismiss denied
- May 2012: DOJ backed NAD
- Jun 2012: Court ruled ADA applies to web-only services
- Oct 2012: Settlement required 100% captioning by 2014

Accessibility and User Impact

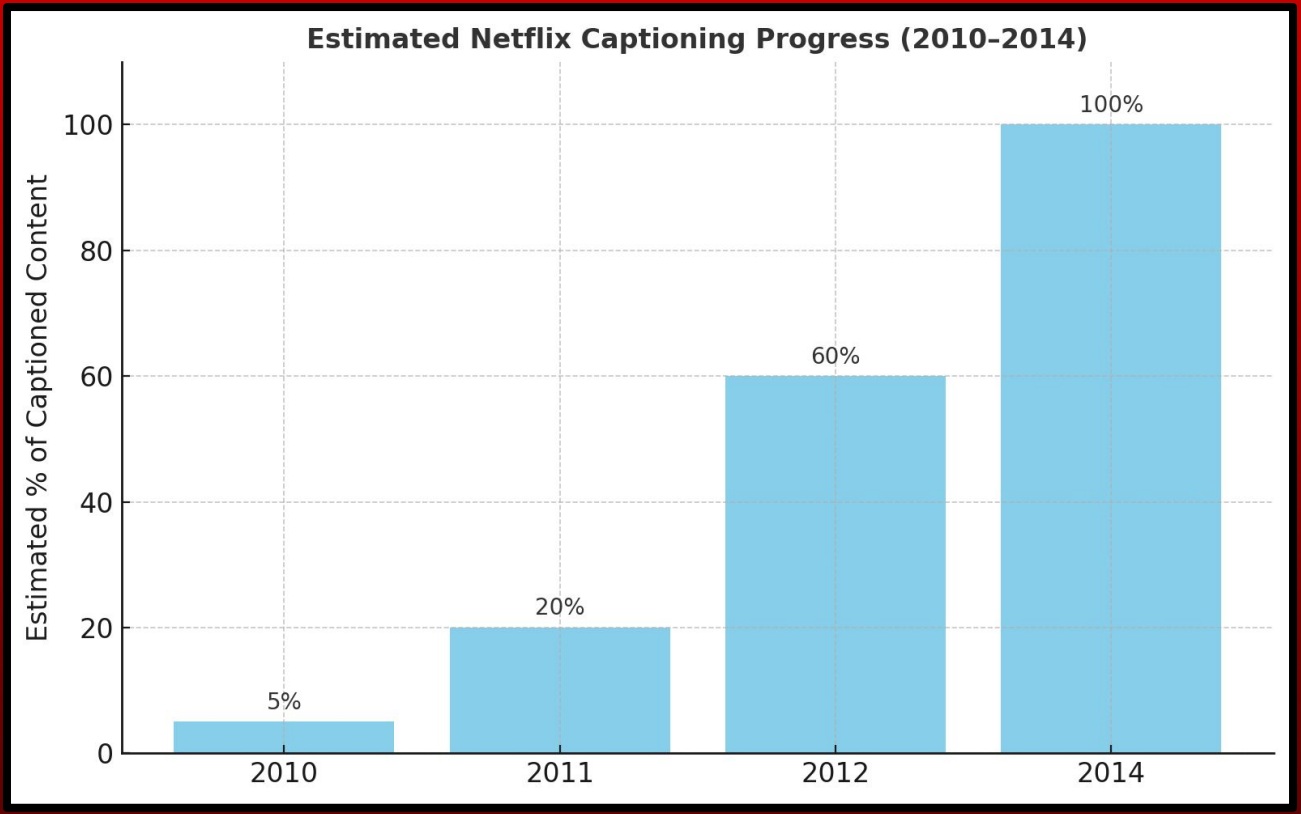


- Captions are essential for deaf and hard-of-hearing users.
- Lack of captions led to isolation and exclusion.
- Case raised awareness and drove industry-wide accessibility improvements.
- Netflix became a model for streaming caption compliance.

Court Decision and Legal Significance

- ADA applies to digital-only services.
- DOJ supported NAD's view.
- Court rejected Netflix's arguments.
- Precedent set for future web accessibility lawsuits.

And the result?



Lessons and Recommendations

- Accessibility is a civil right and legal requirement.
- Captions should be standard from launch.
- Collaborate with advocacy groups.
- Design for all users – universal design improves UX.
- Track accessibility and train development teams.

Thank You